

Africa Conflict Risk Watch



25 SEPTEMBER 2026

Monitoring Alert | Democratic Republic of the Congo



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REPORTING DATE 25 September 2026	DECISION RELEVANCE External alignment, sanctions posture	PRIMARY AREA DR Congo, with Horn of Africa read-across
CONFIDENCE High on the actions, low on intent	TRAJECTORY Widening relief channel	HANDLING Client controlled, not for onward release

Decision-relevant finding

KEY JUDGMENT

The United States removed General Francois Olenga and three entity entries for the Safari Club establishment in Kinshasa from the DRCONGO sanctions programme on 23 September 2026, without a published statement of reasons. Six days earlier the Ethiopia emergency framework lapsed and six Eritrean designations fell with it. The decision-relevant point is not the individual. It is that the administrative relief channel in the DRCONGO programme is demonstrably open at the same time as the Office of Foreign Assets Control is defending a designation against Joseph Kabila, from the same political network, in the District Court for the District of Columbia.

Written on the sequence rather than on the single delisting. The individual action is small. The sequence it belongs to is not.

CONFIDENCE High that both removals occurred as described, resting on the primary Office of Foreign Assets Control notices and, for the Congolese action, two independent Kinshasa outlets [1][3][4][7]. Low on any inference about United States intent, because no statement of reasons exists for the Congolese removal and no delisting petition record has been published.

TRAJECTORY Widening. Two Africa sanctions removals in six days, neither presented as an affirmative policy choice. The direction of travel is toward a narrower active designation footprint in both the Great Lakes and the Red Sea littoral. No evidence yet establishes a common decision behind the two actions.

What changed

EVENT DATE 23 September 2026 for the Congolese removal. 17 and 18 September 2026 for the Ethiopia framework expiry and the consequent removals.

REPORTING DATE 23 to 25 September 2026.

[CONFIRMED] On 23 September 2026 the Office of Foreign Assets Control removed Francois Olenga from the Specially Designated Nationals list under the DRCONGO programme. The listing recorded him as Chef de la Maison Militaire, head of the Military House of the President, with a date of birth of 9 October 1948 and aliases Okunji, Olenga Tate, Olenga Tete and Otshundi. Office of Foreign Assets Control, recent actions, 23 September 2026 [1].

[CONFIRMED] The same action removed three entity entries naming one leisure establishment at Nsele and Gombe, Kinshasa, registration identifier 1322: Safari Club, Centre de Loisir Safari Club, and Safari Beach. Office of Foreign Assets Control, 23 September 2026 [1].

[CONFIRMED] The notice carries no statement of reasons. Radio Okapi records that the Office of Foreign Assets Control did not specify the motives for the decision. Radio Okapi, 24 September 2026 [3]; Actualite.cd, 23 September 2026 [4].

[CONFIRMED] Olenga was designated on 1 June 2017. The stated grounds were that he oversaw security operations directed at opposition groups, and that the Republican Guard obstructed the democratic process. Radio Okapi, 24 September 2026 [3]; United States Department of the Treasury press release, 1 June 2017 [5].

[CONFIRMED] The Office of Foreign Assets Control designated Joseph Kabila on 30 April 2026, announced 1 May 2026, on grounds of support to the AFC and M23. Kabila described the measure as politically motivated. United States Department of the Treasury [6]; Africanews, 1 May 2026 [11].

[CONFIRMED] On 4 August 2026 Kabila filed against the Office of Foreign Assets Control in the United States District Court for the District of Columbia, represented by Erich Ferrari. The filing argues that the designation rests on vague and general allegations without sufficient established proof. Mediacongo, 20 August 2026 [8]; Africanews, 23 August 2026 [12].

[CONFIRMED] The national emergency declared in Executive Order 14046 of 17 September 2021 was not continued beyond 17 September 2026. On 18 September 2026 the Office of Foreign Assets Control removed six designations that rested on that authority: the Eritrean Defense Forces, the People's Front for Democracy and Justice, Hidri Trust, the Red Sea Trading Corporation, Abraha Kassa Nemariam and Hagos Ghebrehwet W Kidan. Office of Foreign Assets Control, 18 September 2026 [7]; Federal Register, 23 September 2026 [9]; Horn Review, 19 September 2026 [10].

[CONFIRMED] A Global Magnitsky designation against Filipos Woldeyohannes, imposed in August 2021, remains in force. Horn Review, 19 September 2026 [10].

[REPORTED] Erich Ferrari is reported to have obtained a delisting for Olenga in 2019 on changed circumstances, after which the Office of Foreign Assets Control re-designated him on other legal grounds. Single-source, Congo Confidential, 24 September 2026 [2]. Confidence capped at low. The Ferrari representation of Kabila is separately corroborated [8][12]; the 2019 Olenga episode is not.

[REPORTED] The United States committed a further 267 million dollars to the Congolese Ebola response, announced 23 and 24 September 2026. Washington Post, 24 September 2026 [13]. Carried as context for United States engagement tempo, not as a sanctions fact.

[UNKNOWN] No statement from the Congolese presidency, government or opposition on the Olenga removal was located in the window. No delisting petition record, no correspondence and no internal document has been published.

[UNKNOWN] Whether the Congolese removal and the Ethiopia framework expiry share any common decision. The expiry was automatic on the terms of the Executive Order. The Congolese removal was discretionary. No evidence connects them.

Why it matters

[ASSESSMENT] The analytic weight sits in the asymmetry between the two Congolese cases rather than in the delisting itself. Olenga, the security officer who ran the Maison Militaire during the period the 2017 designation describes, has been removed without explanation. Kabila, the principal that structure served, is litigating to achieve the same outcome and has not obtained it. One outcome demonstrates that the relief channel functions. The other establishes that it is not being extended to the principal. Assessed at moderate confidence, because the factual base is documentary and complete while the reasoning behind each outcome is not disclosed.

SANCTIONS AS A DIMINISHING INSTRUMENT Two removals in six days reduce the active designation footprint across two theatres. Neither was framed as a policy decision. The Horn action expired on its own terms and the Great Lakes action carried no reasons. The practical effect on the target is the same whether relief is deliberate or administrative, which is the point that matters for deterrent value. A designation regime that contracts silently transmits a weaker signal than one that contracts by announcement, because the absence of stated grounds removes the conditionality that gives the instrument leverage.

LITIGATION AS A SANCTIONS PATHWAY The Kabila filing challenges the evidentiary sufficiency of a designation rather than its policy basis. If the Olenga removal followed an administrative petition on the merits, it establishes that the DRCONGO programme yields to evidentiary pressure. That materially improves the expected value of Kabila's litigation posture without any ruling having been issued. The inference is structural and is held at low to moderate confidence, because no petition record for Olenga has been published.

DOMESTIC POLITICAL TIMING The removal lands during an active constitutional revision and referendum process in Kinshasa, in which the governing coalition marched in support on 22 September and the opposition assembly of 15 September was dispersed. A United States decision that eases pressure on a figure from the predecessor security establishment carries domestic signalling value in that contest, whatever Washington intended. No Congolese actor has yet assigned it such a meaning in public, which is itself an observable.

RED SEA AND GREAT LAKES READ-ACROSS The Eritrean removals restore the formal standing of the Eritrean Defense Forces and the ruling party in the United States financial system at the moment Tigrayan forces seized Mekelle airport, on 23 September, and clashed with federal forces in Afar. Eritrea is a direct party to that theatre. The removals were not caused by it, because the expiry date was fixed in 2021, but the coincidence changes the environment in which Asmara calculates.

Taken together the two actions do not establish a United States policy of sanctions relief in Africa. They establish that the operative constraint on relief is now procedural rather than political in at least two programmes. That is a different system. In a political constraint the designation holds until the policy changes. In a procedural constraint it holds until the authority lapses or the evidentiary record is successfully contested. Actors who read the shift correctly will invest in litigation and in waiting rather than in behavioural change.

Competing pathways

PATHWAY	CURRENT ASSESSMENT	DECISIVE SIGNAL
H1. Routine administrative delisting. Olenga left the Maison Militaire in 2018 and a petition on changed circumstances succeeded on its merits, with no political content.	Most economical explanation and consistent with all observed facts. Held as the working hypothesis at moderate confidence. It does not explain the absence of any published petition record.	No further DRCONGO programme removals by 31 December 2026, and no removal touching an AFC or M23 linked designee in the same period.
H2. Sanctions relief used as an instrument inside the Washington brokered Congo and Rwanda track, including the minerals component.	Plausible but unevicenced. Nothing in the notice, and no United States or Congolese statement, connects the removal to that track. Low confidence.	A second DRCONGO removal, or any removal touching a Rwandan or AFC and M23 linked designee, before 31 December 2026. Alternatively an explicit United States reference to sanctions relief in that negotiation.
H3. A precursor to relief for Kabila himself, whether negotiated or achieved through the District of Columbia litigation.	Speculative. The shared counsel is corroborated, the causal link is not. Held at low confidence and treated as a hypothesis to be tested rather than a reading.	A favourable interim ruling in the District of Columbia case, or an Office of Foreign Assets Control filing conceding any element of the administrative record, before 31 March 2027.
H4. Relief attached to the Safari Club property rather than to the person, reflecting a commercial or ownership change at Nsele and Gombe.	Underexplored. The removal of three entity entries for one establishment alongside the individual is consistent with either a person-led or a property-led petition. Low confidence, not yet differentiated.	A recorded transfer, sale, lease or foreign investment in the Nsele and Gombe establishment, or a Congolese corporate registry change against identifier 1322, within 180 days.

Second-order and cross-border implications

RWANDA AND THE AFC AND M23 TRACK If relief is procedurally rather than politically constrained, designated parties in the eastern theatre gain an incentive to contest the record rather than to modify conduct. That weakens the leverage the designation set was intended to supply to the Washington and Doha processes. No such contest has yet been filed by an AFC or M23 linked designee.

KINSHASA AND THE CONSTITUTIONAL PROCESS The removal supplies material to any Congolese actor seeking to argue that external pressure on the predecessor establishment is receding. The governing coalition and the C64 opposition grouping would draw opposite conclusions from the same fact. Neither has used it. Silence from both is the current observable.

ERITREA, ETHIOPIA AND THE SUDAN FILE The Blue Nile front at Ed Damazin and Kurmuk sits on the Ethiopian border. The standing record carries Sudanese allegations of Ethiopian facilitation of Rapid Support Forces operations and Ethiopian allegations of Sudanese Armed Forces support to Tigray linked forces. A second active front on that border, combined with the restoration of Eritrean institutions to the United States financial system, alters the assumptions behind the Blue Nile watch items without changing any observed fact inside Sudan.

RED SEA LITTORAL AND GULF STATES Removal of the Red Sea Trading Corporation from the designated list reopens a formal commercial channel for the Eritrean ruling party's trading arm. Gulf state and Turkish commercial engagement along the littoral becomes procedurally simpler. No transaction has been observed.

TANZANIA AND EAC MEDIATION No Tanzanian statement on the Congolese events of 15 or 22 September has been located across four consecutive windows. Dar es Salaam's silence during an active EAC mediation role is now a pattern rather than an absence. A shift in United States sanctions posture toward the Great Lakes raises the cost of that silence for Tanzania's mediation standing, without yet compelling a statement.

SADC AND SOUTHERN AFRICA Nil. No SADC instrument, statement or posture change bearing on these actions was located in the window. The absence is recorded rather than inferred from.

Indicators to watch

1. A second removal from the DRCONGO sanctions programme, of any person or entity. Horizon 31 December 2026. This is the single cleanest discriminator between H1 and H2.
2. Publication by the Office of Foreign Assets Control, or disclosure through litigation, of a delisting petition record for Olenga. Horizon 31 March 2027. Presence supports H1 and strengthens H3 by demonstrating the channel. Absence leaves H4 open.

3. Any substantive docket movement in Kabila against the Office of Foreign Assets Control in the District Court for the District of Columbia, including a government response, a motion to dismiss, or an administrative record filing. Horizon 31 March 2027.
4. A statement from the Congolese presidency, government, UDPS or the C64 grouping referring to the Olenga removal. Horizon 31 October 2026. Continued silence from all four is the falsifiable expectation.
5. A recorded ownership, transfer or investment change at the Nsele and Gombe establishment, or against Congolese registry identifier 1322. Horizon 31 March 2027. This is the only indicator that isolates H4.
6. Any Eritrean transaction, banking relationship or commercial agreement involving the Red Sea Trading Corporation or the People's Front for Democracy and Justice that becomes public. Horizon 31 December 2026.
7. Any Sudanese Armed Forces or Rapid Support Forces statement referencing the Ethiopian or Eritrean developments, or any posture change at Ed Damazin or Kurmuk attributable to them. Horizon 25 October 2026. Carried forward unchanged from 24 September.
8. A United States statement, in any forum, linking sanctions relief to the Congo and Rwanda negotiation. Horizon 31 December 2026. This would convert H2 from plausible to supported.

Risk-brief update

UPDATED JUDGMENT

Treat United States sanctions posture toward the Great Lakes and the Horn as a variable rather than as a fixed constraint for the remainder of 2026. The operative question for any client exposure modelled on designation status is no longer whether Washington's policy changes. It is whether the underlying authority survives and whether the evidentiary record withstands contest. Both are observable in advance.

Recommended rating changes

- ELEVATE. United States sanctions posture, Great Lakes. From stable to variable. Two removals in six days across two African programmes, neither announced as policy, is a measurable change in the tempo of relief.
- ELEVATE. Eritrea and Red Sea littoral, external alignment. The Eritrean Defense Forces and the ruling party are no longer designated under the Ethiopia authority. This is a change in kind, not degree, and it coincides with renewed fighting in Tigray.
- MAINTAIN. DRC civic space and political assembly, at the elevated level set on 24 September. The differential access finding is unchanged. Nothing in this window bears on it.
- MAINTAIN. DRC constitutional process, at the elevated level set on 24 September. The referendum bill has not moved to committee or plenary.
- MAINTAIN. DRC eastern theatre. No in-window change to territorial control or force posture was located.
- MAINTAIN. Mozambique northern theatre. The Muidumbe and Macomia incident of 23 September is consistent with the established pattern and does not meet the materiality test. The Niassa second-incident watch item stands open to 6 October.
- MAINTAIN. Tanzania political contestation. The final submissions and the adjournment to 26 September are procedural. The original trial end date of 25 September passes today without a judgment date fixed, which is an indicator rather than an event.
- DOWNGRADE. The Uvira and Kananga detention item, from an open closure deadline to an unresolved documentation gap. The 25 September deadline falls today and no release or continued-detention report has been located for either city across three windows. The absence is a reporting gap, not evidence of continued detention.
- RETIRE. The Mauritania Beijing forum instrument watch. Eight windows have closed with nothing located. Closed in the negative as scheduled. Reopen only on evidence of a China-facing instrument.

Source limitations

CORROBORATED Both sanctions actions rest on primary Office of Foreign Assets Control notices, which are the authoritative record and require no corroboration. The Congolese action is additionally carried by two independent Kinshasa outlets. The

Ethiopia expiry is additionally carried by the Federal Register and by two regional outlets. The Kabila filing is carried by two independent outlets. The corroboration rule is satisfied for every fact-tier claim in this alert.

ACCESS LIMITATION Direct index fetching remained unavailable this run. Every retrieval followed the search-then-fetch pattern recorded on 23 September. Two fetches were refused on that basis, being a Radio Okapi security item and a Sudan Tribune trade item, both of which were reached through alternative carriers or left at headline level. Four Tier 1 nils, for Mauritania, Burkina Faso, Togo and Benin, are approval limited rather than index limited and should not be read as evidence of quiet.

INFORMATION RISK One false positive was caught and rejected. A search result associated Federal Register notice 91 FR 60490 with the Congolese removal. The notice in fact records the Ethiopia and Eritrea removals of 18 September. Citing it against the Congolese action would have produced a fabricated documentary chain. A second false positive was caught in the Congolese file: an infos.cd report of two deaths in a police confrontation at a Beni cemetery during a tribute to Delcat Idengo is dated 26 March 2025 and was rejected. It surfaces alongside a genuine and unrelated Beni incident of 24 September 2026.

MISSING EVIDENCE No delisting petition, no statement of reasons, no internal correspondence and no United States official comment on the Congolese removal. No Congolese reaction of any kind. Without a petition record the differentiation between H1 and H4 cannot be made. The single most valuable missing document is the administrative record that the District of Columbia litigation may compel the Office of Foreign Assets Control to file.

Source register

SOURCE	TYPE	CLAIM USE	LIMITATION AND INDEPENDENCE
Office of Foreign Assets Control, recent actions, 23 September 2026	Tier 1 primary or official	The Congolese removal, the named aliases, the three Safari Club entity entries and registry identifier 1322	Authoritative and self-sufficient. Carries no statement of reasons, which is the central evidentiary gap in this alert.
Office of Foreign Assets Control, recent actions, 18 September 2026	Tier 1 primary or official	The Ethiopia emergency expiry and the six consequent Eritrean removals	Authoritative. Expiry is automatic on the terms of Executive Order 14046 and implies no policy decision.
Federal Register, notice 91 FR 60490, 23 September 2026	Tier 1 primary or official	Publication record of the Eritrean removals	Independent of the Office of Foreign Assets Control web notice only in form, not in substance. Same issuing authority. Not evidence of the Congolese action.
Radio Okapi, 24 September 2026	Tier 1 primary or official	The Congolese removal, the absence of stated motives, the 1 June 2017 designation and its grounds	United Nations supported Congolese broadcaster. Independent of Actualite.cd. Reports the Treasury action rather than witnessing it.
Actualite.cd, 23 September 2026	Tier 1 primary or official	The Congolese removal, first Kinshasa carrier	Congolese outlet, independent of Radio Okapi. Same underlying Treasury source.
Mediacongo, 20 August 2026	Tier 4 secondary or aggregated	The Kabila filing date, court, counsel and pleaded grounds	Aggregator. Independent of Africanews in ownership. Detail level exceeds the wire reports, which is a reason for caution as well as for use.
Africanews, 1 May and 23 August 2026	Tier 3 international press	The Kabila designation and the fact of the court challenge	Corroborates Mediacongo on the challenge. Does not carry the filing detail.
Horn Review, 19 September 2026	Tier 4 secondary or aggregated	The expiry versus lifting distinction and the surviving Global Magnitsky designation	Regional think tank with an analytic position. Used for the legal distinction, which is verifiable against the primary notice, not for its judgment.
Congo Confidentiel, 24 September 2026	Tier 4 secondary or aggregated	The 2019 Olenga delisting and re-designation episode	Single-source and uncorroborated. Substack publication with an evident editorial line. Confidence capped at low. The shared counsel claim is corroborated elsewhere; the 2019 episode is not.
Washington Post, 24 September 2026	Tier 3 international press	The additional 267 million dollar Ebola commitment	Context only. Carried to establish United States engagement tempo, not as a sanctions fact.

References

- [1] Democratic Republic of the Congo-related Designations Removals. Office of Foreign Assets Control, United States Department of the Treasury, 23 September 2026
- [2] Olenga retire de la liste noire americaine: derriere la decision de Washington, le precedent Ferrari qui interesse Kabila. Congo Confidentiel, 24 September 2026
- [3] Washington leve les sanctions contre le general Francois Olenga et le complexe Safari Beach. Radio Okapi, 24 September 2026
- [4] RDC: Washington retire le general Francois Olenga de sa liste de sanctions. Actualite.cd, 23 September 2026
- [5] Treasury sanctions senior Democratic Republic of the Congo officials. United States Department of the Treasury, press release, 1 June 2017
- [6] Treasury Sanctions Former Democratic Republic of the Congo President for Ties to Armed Conflict. United States Department of the Treasury, 2026
- [7] Expiration of Emergency With Respect to the Situation in Ethiopia; Ethiopia-related Designations Removals. Office of Foreign Assets Control, 18 September 2026
- [8] Sanctions americaines: Joseph Kabila conteste devant la justice americaine. Mediacongo, 20 August 2026
- [9] Notice of OFAC Sanctions Action, 91 FR 60490. Federal Register, 23 September 2026
- [10] Eritrea's Sanctions Expired, Not Formally Lifted. Bezawit Eshetu, Horn Review, 19 September 2026
- [11] Former DR Congo President Joseph Kabila hit with US sanctions. Africanews, 1 May 2026
- [12] DRC: Ex-president Kabila challenges US sanctions in court. Africanews, 23 August 2026
- [13] U.S. pledges an additional \$267 million to contain fast-spreading Ebola. Washington Post, 24 September 2026

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